partner in negotiations with Lord Irwin. Police atrocities were one of three items specifically enumerated as requiring Viscount Irwin's investigation. Yet the Mahatma gave up on it. As Bose goes on to lament, 'With better bargaining, even in March 1931, one could have expected more from the government, because they were really anxious for the settlement.' If the government were really that anxious, why did the Mahatma not drive the point home? Bose has an answer which places the blame squarely on the Mahatma. He explains that 'men with fixed ideas are not well qualified for political bargaining' and that '[s]o far as the Mahatma is concerned, he alternates between obstinacy and leniency and moreover, he is too susceptible to personal appeals – and with such habits of mind, it is difficult to get the better of one's opponent in political bargaining'.[16] That is quite a damning indictment of the Mahatma's failure to deploy his much-vaunted political skills in the case of Bhagat Singh. If this is right, at the very least, Gandhi gave up on saving Bhagat Singh because Irwin impressed upon him that this is what he should do in a personal appeal. This is clear from Gandhi's declaration (not mentioned by Bose in his book), 'If the boys are to be hanged let them be hanged before the Karachi Congress', which is exactly what came to pass on the night of 23 March 1931.

It is unsurprising, therefore, that others have argued that in the final analysis Gandhi actually made no effort at all to save the life of Bhagat Singh and his two condemned comrades. Mr Makandey Katju is a former judge, spending much of his time presently in southern California in comfortable retirement. He served as chief justice of both the Allahabad High Court and the Delhi High Court, before being elevated to the Supreme Court of India in 2006, where he remained for the next five years. He hails from an illustrious lineage of Hindu Pandits. The Katjus lived in the enclosure of the ancient Kathlishwar Temple, from which they derive their name, and from where for generations they had served the nawabs of Jaora. In more modern times, Mr Markendey's grandfather was Dr Kailas Nath Katju. He became the union home and law minister under Prime Minister Jawaharlal Nehru, who was also another Kashmiri Pandit. It was his great-grandfather, Mansa Ram Katju, who had in fact some 200 years ago left the